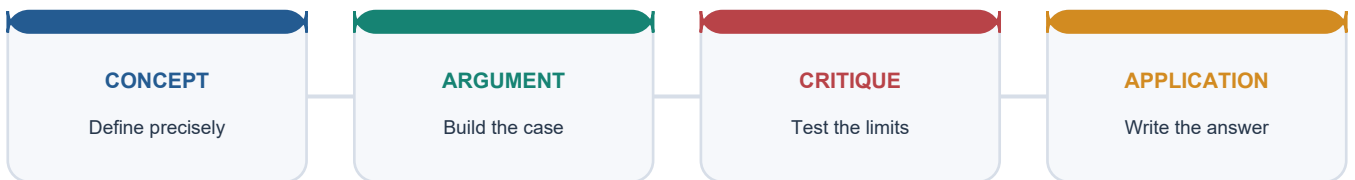


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

The Aryan Problem and Identity of Aryan Culture: Complete Learning Session

Complete Learning Session

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Learning Session Contents

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Aryan Problem and Identity of Aryan Culture: Complete Learning Session

Subject: Ancient History | **Paper:** Prelims GS-I with GS-I historical/cultural support | **Level:** Core first; Optional Advanced separately labelled **Source order:** canonical Ancient History Core owner; separately labelled Advanced owner; official syllabus and repository PYQ routing; OCR-searchable R.S. Sharma and Upinder Singh; dated peer-reviewed archaeogenetic studies. **Evidence rule:** separate fact, interpretation and unresolved question. *Arya* is not treated as a biological race; language, material culture, ancestry and identity are never collapsed.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

COVERAGE AND CONTROL LEDGER

Required dimension	Sessions
Meaning, category firewall, history of the question and colonial racialisation	1-3
Comparative linguistics, Indo-Iranian and Mitanni	4-5
Triangulation, Rigvedic source limits, geography and material vocabulary	6-9
Horse/chariot and Harappan/post-Harappan transition	10-11
Cemetery H, Swat, OCP, PGW, BMAC and Sintashta	12-14
Invasion, migration, indigenous-continuity and interaction models	15
Archaeogenetic method, Rakhigarhi and wider 2019 evidence	16-18
Acculturation, political misuse, unresolved questions and answer method	19-22

ORIGIN AND SCHOLARLY TIMELINE

Stage	Development	Methodological significance
Late 18th-19th centuries	Comparative philology identifies systematic relationships among Sanskrit and Indo-European languages	Secure linguistic relationship; not race
19th-early 20th centuries	Linguistic "Aryan" is racialised in colonial and European theory	Category error and hierarchy
1920s-1940s	Harappan discovery followed by Chanda-Wheeler invasion interpretation	Text, skeletons and decline compressed into one story
1960s-1990s	Archaeological, contextual and osteological critiques reject the massacre/destruction model	No civilisation-wide invasion horizon
Late 20th-early 21st centuries	Migration, interaction, contact linguistics and regional archaeology gain priority	Movement separated from conquest
2019	Shinde et al. and Narasimhan et al. publish peer-reviewed ancient-DNA studies	New ancestry evidence with strict sample/model limits
Present method	Archaeology + text + linguistics + genetics, with political misuse controlled	Graded, revisable synthesis

PROGRESSIVE ROADMAP

1. Define every category before weighing evidence.
2. Understand how philology was racialised and later corrected.
3. Establish linguistic relationship and external chronology.
4. Read the Rig Veda by genre, layer and geography.
5. Separate horse, chariot and archaeological-culture claims.
6. Compare invasion, migration, continuity and interaction models.
7. Use dated genetics without turning ancestry into language.
8. Conclude through facts, interpretations and unresolved questions.

SESSION 1 - THE CATEGORY FIREWALL: ARYA, ARYAN AND INDO-ARYAN

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Arya is a contextual textual self-designation; Indo-Aryan is a linguistic subgroup. Neither is a valid biological-race label.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Begin by separating language, textual identity, archaeological culture and ancestry; most bad answers fail before the evidence is even weighed.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

arya; Indo-Aryan; Indo-Iranian; language family; self-designation; ancestry

VISUAL FIRST

LANGUAGE != RACE != GENES != POTTERY != ETHNICITY != CIVILISATION
learned speech ancestry assemblage historical boundary

CORE TEACHING

In Rigvedic usage, *arya* can mark an insider, ally, respectable person or participant in a ritual-political order. Its force varies by hymn and relationship. It does not identify a timeless phenotype. "Indo-Aryan" belongs to historical linguistics: it names a branch of Indo-Iranian languages and, cautiously, communities using them. "Aryan culture" is therefore only a heuristic for traits represented in early Vedic texts and related evidence; it is not a one-pottery, one-skeleton or one-gene entity.

The same caution applies to *dasa/dasyu*. These terms can identify enemies, outsiders or rival ritual and political groups. They cannot be translated mechanically into a biological indigenous race. Conflict among groups described as *arya* further defeats a simple two-race map.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** Upinder Singh explicitly treats Indo-European and Indo-Aryan as linguistic, not racial, terms; the Rig Veda uses identity terms contextually rather than as modern census categories.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The term *arya* should be treated as a contextual self-designation rather than a racial essence. Rigvedic passages use it within shifting alliances, ritual status and social boundaries, while Indo-Aryan is a linguistic classification. This distinction blocks the colonial conversion of language into biology. It does not, however, deny that speakers and populations moved; it only requires movement to be demonstrated through independent evidence.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Do not write "Aryan race" or assume every *dasa* reference identifies a dark-skinned indigenous population.

MAINS USE

Use this as the compulsory opening firewall in any origin, identity or migration answer.

MINI RECAP

Arya is contextual; Indo-Aryan is linguistic; neither is a race.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

THE CATEGORY FIREWALL: ARYA, ARYAN AND INDO-ARYAN

- > KEYWORDS: arya; Indo-Aryan; Indo-Iranian; language family; self-designation; ancestry
- > ANSWER LINE: Begin by separating language, textual identity, archaeological culture and ancestry; most bad answers fail before the evidence is even weighed.
- > RECAP: Arya is contextual; Indo-Aryan is linguistic; neither is a race.

SESSION 2 - WHY THE ARYAN QUESTION EXISTS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

The Aryan problem is an interdisciplinary reconstruction problem created by sources that measure different things and survive unevenly.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The controversy persists not because evidence is absent, but because text, language, objects and genes answer non-identical questions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

source asymmetry; undeciphered script; oral corpus; sampling; triangulation; confidence

VISUAL FIRST

RIG VEDA: words/worldview ----+
ARCHAEOLOGY: objects/context ----+--> TRIANGULATION --> graded conclusion
LINGUISTICS: language history ---+
aDNA: sampled ancestry -----+

CORE TEACHING

The Rig Veda is ritual-poetic, orally transmitted and layered. Harappan writing remains undeciphered. Archaeological assemblages cannot announce the language or ethnicity of their users, and South Asian ancient-DNA sampling remains geographically and socially uneven. Linguistics securely establishes relationship but not a complete route or political event.

Accordingly, the problem contains several questions: the family of Vedic Sanskrit; the geography and chronology of the early corpus; movement into or within South Asia; the relationship between Harappan and Vedic worlds; and the process through which identities formed. These questions may receive answers of different confidence.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** The canonical Core owner separates linguistic relationship, textual geography, population movement, Harappan-Vedic relationship and material-culture identification as distinct questions.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The Aryan problem is best framed as a problem of source asymmetry. Comparative linguistics securely places Vedic Sanskrit within Indo-Iranian, whereas the Rig Veda supplies a layered textual world, archaeology supplies material sequences, and genetics supplies sampled ancestry. Their partial convergence permits a migration-and-interaction hypothesis. Yet the sources do not yield a named migrating people, exact route or one-to-one material culture.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Uncertainty does not mean that every claim is equally plausible; grade conclusions by source strength.

MAINS USE

Turn the introduction into a hierarchy of confidence rather than an ideological declaration.

MINI RECAP

Different questions require different evidence and different confidence levels.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

WHY THE ARYAN QUESTION EXISTS

- > KEYWORDS: source asymmetry; undeciphered script; oral corpus; sampling; triangulation; confidence
- > ANSWER LINE: The controversy persists not because evidence is absent, but because text, language, objects and genes answer non-identical questions.
- > RECAP: Different questions require different evidence and different confidence levels.

SESSION 3 - HISTORIOGRAPHY: PHILOLOGY, RACIALISATION AND CORRECTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Historiography traces how a valid linguistic discovery was converted into racial and civilisational theories and later re-examined.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Comparative philology survives; the race hierarchy built upon it does not.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

comparative philology; colonial knowledge; race theory; invasion; nationalist response; presentism

VISUAL FIRST

18th-19th c. language comparison

- > Indo-European relationship
- > colonial racial hierarchy
- > invasion master-story
- > archaeological critique
- > migration + interaction + source limits

CORE TEACHING

Early modern scholars recognised systematic similarities among Sanskrit, Greek, Latin, Avestan and other languages. Nineteenth- and early twentieth-century scholarship often transformed this linguistic relationship into a supposedly superior Aryan biological race. Colonial hierarchies and later European racial politics gave that conversion political force.

Mortimer Wheeler's invasion interpretation linked Rigvedic "fort destroyer" imagery and Mohenjo-daro skeletons to an Aryan assault. Later contextual study showed that the skeletons did not belong to one massacre horizon and that no civilisation-wide military destruction layer exists. Nationalist reactions correctly challenged racial hierarchy but can reproduce essentialism if they treat complete indigenous purity as a prior conclusion.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** Upinder Singh records the Chanda-Wheeler invasion thesis and the later refutations by P.V. Kane, George Dales, B.B. Lal and K.A.R. Kennedy; R.S. Sharma treats movement without requiring mass replacement.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Colonial scholarship distorted the Aryan question by turning language relationship into racial hierarchy and then reading Harappan decline through invasion. Wheeler's massacre model relied on textual imagery and decontextualised skeletons, but later archaeological and osteological review rejected a single assault horizon. This removes the violent master-story. It does not logically remove all mobility, which must be tested afresh through linguistics, archaeology and genetics.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Rejecting colonial race theory is not evidence that all migration hypotheses are colonial inventions.

MAINS USE

Use a short historiographical chronology, then move quickly to present evidence standards.

MINI RECAP

Keep the linguistic discovery; discard racial typology and monocausal invasion.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

HISTORIOGRAPHY: PHILOLOGY, RACIALISATION AND CORRECTION

-> KEYWORDS: comparative philology; colonial knowledge; race theory; invasion; nationalist response; presentism

-> ANSWER LINE: Comparative philology survives; the race hierarchy built upon it does not.

-> RECAP: Keep the linguistic discovery; discard racial typology and monocausal invasion.

SESSION 4 - COMPARATIVE LINGUISTICS AND THE INDO-EUROPEAN FAMILY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Comparative linguistics reconstructs language relationships through regular sound correspondences, shared grammar and inherited vocabulary.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Regular patterns establish descent more securely than isolated similar words, but descent alone does not draw a migration map.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

cognate; sound law; morphology; reconstruction; borrowing; homeland

VISUAL FIRST

PROTO-INDO-EUROPEAN

```
|
+-- many branches
|
|-- PROTO-INDO-IRANIAN
    +-- Indo-Aryan
    +-- Iranian
    |-- Nuristani
```

CORE TEACHING

A few look-alike words may be accidental or borrowed. The comparative method instead looks for regular correspondences across phonology, morphology and basic inherited vocabulary. Vedic Sanskrit belongs to Indo-Aryan, which belongs to Indo-Iranian within the Indo-European family.

This is the strongest stable conclusion in the debate. It demonstrates historical relationship and branching. It cannot by itself identify one archaeological homeland, exact route, migration size, conquest or biological population. Loanwords and areal features must also be separated from inherited forms.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** Vedic Sanskrit and Avestan share systematic language structure and inherited vocabulary; Vedic *soma* and Avestan *haoma* illustrate relationship plus later divergence.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Comparative linguistics provides the firmest foundation of the debate because systematic sound and grammatical correspondences place Vedic Sanskrit within Indo-Iranian and Indo-European. Shared inherited forms are stronger than isolated resemblance and cannot be dismissed as coincidence. They establish language descent and divergence. They do not independently locate every speaker or prove that a particular burial assemblage carried that language.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: One cognate never proves a homeland, migration route or archaeological identity.

MAINS USE

Place linguistics first in the evidence hierarchy, followed immediately by its limits.

MINI RECAP

Language relationship is secure; its social and geographic history needs other evidence.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

COMPARATIVE LINGUISTICS AND THE INDO-EUROPEAN FAMILY

- > KEYWORDS: cognate; sound law; morphology; reconstruction; borrowing; homeland
- > ANSWER LINE: Regular patterns establish descent more securely than isolated similar words, but descent alone does not draw a migration map.
- > RECAP: Language relationship is secure; its social and geographic history needs other evidence.

SESSION 5 - INDO-IRANIAN RELATIONSHIP AND MITANNI ATTESTATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Indo-Iranian comparison and Mitanni records provide linguistic chronology outside South Asia without supplying a direct route map.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mitanni is an external attestation of Indo-Aryan forms, not proof that the Rig Veda was composed in West Asia.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Avestan; soma-haoma; Mitanni; Bogazkoy; Kikkuli; superstrate

VISUAL FIRST

```
VEDIC <---- shared Indo-Iranian inheritance ----> AVESTAN
      |
      +--> Mitanni divine names + horse-training terms
            (restricted external attestation, c. 15th-14th c. BCE)
```

CORE TEACHING

Vedic and Avestan share inherited linguistic and ritual vocabulary, while also preserving later divergences and reversals. A treaty from Bogazkoy, conventionally dated around the fourteenth century BCE, invokes forms corresponding to Mitra, Varuna, Indra and the Nasatyas. A horse-training text associated with Kikkuli contains technical forms compared with Indo-Aryan numerals and vocabulary.

Most Mitanni speakers used Hurrian. The Indo-Aryan elements therefore appear restricted, perhaps as elite or technical vocabulary. They establish that Indo-Aryan forms existed outside South Asia by the mid-second millennium BCE; they do not prove a Mitanni-to-India migration or date a Rigvedic hymn.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** Upinder Singh discusses the Bogazkoy treaty, Kikkuli vocabulary and the Hurrian majority language as a bounded external attestation.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Mitanni evidence strengthens the chronological and comparative case for a wider Indo-Aryan history. Divine names in the Bogazkoy treaty and technical horse vocabulary occur in a Near Eastern political setting where Hurrian remained dominant. The evidence therefore supports restricted Indo-Aryan linguistic presence outside South Asia. It neither identifies the ancestry of the whole Mitanni population nor supplies a direct itinerary into the subcontinent.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: External Indo-Aryan vocabulary is not a demographic census and does not date the Rig Veda exactly.

MAINS USE

Use Mitanni as one named paragraph, never as the whole argument.

MINI RECAP

Mitanni adds external chronology, not a complete migration narrative.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

INDO-IRANIAN RELATIONSHIP AND MITANNI ATTESTATION

- > KEYWORDS: Avestan; soma-haoma; Mitanni; Bogazkoy; Kikkuli; superstrate
- > ANSWER LINE: Mitanni is an external attestation of Indo-Aryan forms, not proof that the Rig Veda was composed in West Asia.
- > RECAP: Mitanni adds external chronology, not a complete migration narrative.

SESSION 6 - THE EVIDENCE LADDER AND TRIANGULATION TEST

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Triangulation compares independent evidence only after matching chronology, geography, scale and the variable each source measures.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Convergence strengthens a claim only when the datasets are independently dated, geographically relevant and conceptually non-equivalent.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

chronology; geography; scale; independence; representativeness; alternative hypothesis

VISUAL FIRST

- 1 DATE each source
 - > 2 LOCATE it
 - > 3 DEFINE what it measures
 - > 4 TEST independence
 - > 5 COMPARE alternatives
 - > 6 GRADE confidence

CORE TEACHING

Linguistics can establish descent and contact; texts can establish remembered language, ideals and places; archaeology can establish settlement, technology, diet and burial; genetics can establish ancestry relationships among sampled persons. None should be translated directly into another.

A valid convergence claim must ask whether the evidence belongs to the same period and region, whether the social scale is comparable, and whether one dataset was interpreted using assumptions borrowed from another.

Contradictions should be preserved rather than averaged away.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** The Basic owner's evidence matrix and the source-critical approach of R.S. Sharma and Upinder Singh support a staged, interdisciplinary method.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

A migration hypothesis gains strength when independent linguistic, archaeological and genetic patterns align in chronology and geography. For example, Indo-Iranian linguistic history, second-millennium interaction corridors and later Steppe-related ancestry can be compared. Their convergence raises plausibility. Yet genes do not prove language, and material parallels may arise through exchange, so the conclusion must remain a model of movement and interaction rather than an ethnic equation.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Do not call two correlated claims independent if one was inferred from the other.

MAINS USE

Use the six-step ladder as a source-criticism paragraph or conclusion.

MINI RECAP

Match time, place, scale and category before claiming convergence.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

THE EVIDENCE LADDER AND TRIANGULATION TEST

-> KEYWORDS: chronology; geography; scale; independence; representativeness; alternative hypothesis

-> ANSWER LINE: Convergence strengthens a claim only when the datasets are independently dated, geographically relevant and conceptually non-equivalent.

-> RECAP: Match time, place, scale and category before claiming convergence.

SESSION 7 - RIG VEDA AS A LAYERED HISTORICAL SOURCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

The Rig Veda is an orally transmitted ritual-poetic corpus whose historical clues require genre and layer criticism.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Rig Veda is indispensable evidence for a textual world, but it is neither a dated migration diary nor an archaeological report.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

oral transmission; family books; ritual poetry; elite authorship; layer; context

VISUAL FIRST

```
HYMN / FORMULA / PRAISE / MYTH
  |
contextual reading
  |
family-book layer + vocabulary cluster + independent chronology
  |
bounded historical inference
```

CORE TEACHING

Books 2-7 are conventionally treated as older family books, while Books 1, 8, 9 and 10 contain much later material, although old and new compositions cannot be reduced to a perfect book order. The corpus reflects specialist ritual authorship and preserves cattle, horse, chariot, kinship, conflict, deity and river vocabulary.

Oral transmission can preserve language with great care, but compilation, genre and metaphor complicate historical extraction. A hymn may contain memory, praise, myth and polemic together. Historians therefore use clusters of references and compare them with external chronology and archaeology.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** R.S. Sharma and Upinder Singh both use Rigvedic vocabulary while warning against treating the text as a simple chronological narrative.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The Rig Veda offers unmatched evidence for early Indo-Aryan language and elite ritual culture. Its family books preserve river, cattle, kinship and political vocabulary that locates a broad north-western milieu. Because it is layered ritual poetry transmitted orally, individual verses cannot be read as dated battlefield reports. Historical reconstruction must therefore use repeated patterns and independent archaeological chronology.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Neither "oral means worthless" nor "sacred text means literal chronicle" is defensible.

MAINS USE

Pair every textual inference with genre and chronology limits.

MINI RECAP

Use the corpus intensively, but never literally or as a census.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

RIG VEDA AS A LAYERED HISTORICAL SOURCE

- > KEYWORDS: oral transmission; family books; ritual poetry; elite authorship; layer; context
- > ANSWER LINE: The Rig Veda is indispensable evidence for a textual world, but it is neither a dated migration diary nor an archaeological report.
- > RECAP: Use the corpus intensively, but never literally or as a census.

SESSION 8 - RIGVEDIC GEOGRAPHY AND THE SARASVATI QUESTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Rigvedic textual geography reconstructs a remembered north-western landscape; river identifications remain layer- and chronology-sensitive.

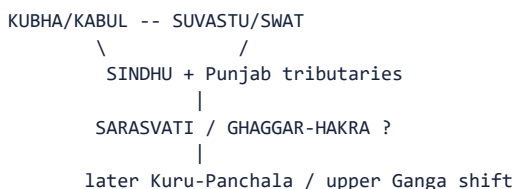
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A palaeochannel, a settlement distribution and a textual hydronym are three datasets, not three names for one proven fact.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Sapta-Sindhu; Sindhu; Punjab rivers; Ghaggar-Hakra; palaeochannel; hydronym

VISUAL FIRST



CORE TEACHING

The strongest early textual geography is in the north-west: the Sindhu, Punjab tributaries and rivers linked to the Kabul-Swat zone. Later Vedic material shifts toward Kuru-Panchala and the upper Ganga. River-name clusters locate a broad composition and memory zone, not a fenced ethnic frontier.

Sarasvati is often related to the Ghaggar-Hakra system, but the identification cannot be made automatic.

Palaeochannel history, water discharge, Harappan site chronology, textual layering and the possibility of transferred or remembered names must be tested independently.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** The family-book geography and the later eastward shift are treated in the canonical owner and Upinder Singh; palaeochannel-to-text identification remains explicitly debated.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Rigvedic hydonyms support a north-western textual horizon. The concentration of Sindhu and tributary references makes this a stronger inference than an all-India setting. Sarasvati-Ghaggar-Hakra correlations may illuminate memory and landscape change. They cannot by themselves identify Harappan language or settle ultimate homeland and migration direction because channel dates, settlement phases and textual layers are separate.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Do not use Sarasvati identification as a single-fact verdict for Harappan-Vedic identity.

MAINS USE

Draw a small river schematic and write "composition zone, not ethnic frontier."

MINI RECAP

Textual geography is regional evidence; river identity needs independent dating.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

RIGVEDIC GEOGRAPHY AND THE SARASVATI QUESTION

- > KEYWORDS: Sapta-Sindhu; Sindhu; Punjab rivers; Ghaggar-Hakra; palaeochannel; hydronym
- > ANSWER LINE: A palaeochannel, a settlement distribution and a textual hydronym are three datasets, not three names for one proven fact.
- > RECAP: Textual geography is regional evidence; river identity needs independent dating.

SESSION 9 - PASTORAL-AGRICULTURAL VOCABULARY AND TEXTUAL LIMITS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Rigvedic material depicts pastoral predominance within a mixed agro-pastoral economy, not exclusive nomadism.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cattle-centred value and mobility coexisted with cultivation, wells, craft and settled households.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

go; gavishti; plough; avata; kulya; ayas; agro-pastoral

VISUAL FIRST

CATTLE / PASTURE / RAID
+ PLOUGH / SOW / HARVEST
+ WELL / CHANNEL
+ CART / WEAVING / CRAFT
= mixed agro-pastoral textual economy

CORE TEACHING

Cattle vocabulary expresses wealth, gift, subsistence and conflict. Yet the corpus also refers to ploughing, sowing, harvesting, wells, channels, carts, weaving, carpentry and leatherwork. Pastoral values were prominent, but agriculture was known.

Text frequency is not a quantitative economic survey. Nor should every occurrence of *ayas* be translated as iron; early contexts fit a copper/bronze material world better, while iron becomes central in later Vedic and early Iron Age settings.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** R.S. Sharma's chapter identifies cattle-centred pastoral life alongside agriculture and crafts; the 2026 routed vocabulary questions reinforce precise term use but have no direct origin verdict.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Rigvedic vocabulary supports an agro-pastoral cultural profile. Terms for cattle wealth and raids reveal pastoral values, while ploughing, wells and harvest vocabulary demonstrate cultivation. The combination is more explanatory than either nomadic or fully agrarian caricature. Since a ritual corpus does not measure occupational shares, the conclusion should describe emphasis rather than claim a statistical economy.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Pastoral predominance is not total nomadism, and early *ayas* is not automatic iron.

MAINS USE

Use this evidence only to describe textual culture, not to identify a pottery horizon.

MINI RECAP

Cattle-centred values operated within a mixed productive economy.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

PASTORAL-AGRICULTURAL VOCABULARY AND TEXTUAL LIMITS

- > KEYWORDS: go; gavishti; plough; avata; kulya; ayas; agro-pastoral
- > ANSWER LINE: Cattle-centred value and mobility coexisted with cultivation, wells, craft and settled households.
- > RECAP: Cattle-centred values operated within a mixed productive economy.

SESSION 10 - HORSE, EQUID AND CHARIOT: THREE DISTINCT CLAIMS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Horse presence, horse centrality and light spoked-wheel chariot technology are separate propositions requiring different evidence.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

An equid bone does not prove horse centrality, and a solid-wheel vehicle does not become a light spoked war chariot.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

equid identification; context; ashva; ratha; spoked wheel; solid wheel

VISUAL FIRST

EQUID BONE --species/context?--> HORSE PRESENCE
HORSE PRESENCE --frequency/use?--> ECONOMIC OR RITUAL CENTRALITY
VEHICLE --wheel/form/draught?--> LIGHT SPOKED CHARIOT

CORE TEACHING

Vedic and Indo-Iranian texts assign high symbolic and elite value to horse and chariot. Archaeological evaluation must distinguish species identification, stratigraphic context, frequency, vehicle form and chronology.

Surkotada equid identifications remain debated. Harappan cart models generally show solid-wheel transport. Sintashta provides early second-millennium BCE spoked-wheel vehicle contexts, but archaeological technology alone does not identify language. Sanauli's vehicles have solid wheels; their draught animals and exact function are not established.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** The canonical package uses Surkotada, Sintashta, Mitanni and Sanauli to separate animal, vehicle and linguistic evidence; Upinder Singh treats Sanauli implications as unresolved.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Horse and chariot evidence is valuable only after decomposition. Rigvedic *ashva* and *ratha* show textual importance, while Sintashta burials provide dated spoked-wheel technology and Mitanni provides external technical vocabulary. Surkotada and Sanauli raise South Asian questions but remain contested in species or vehicle form. The convergence is suggestive; no single bone or cart fixes ethnicity.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Never substitute "vehicle" for "horse-drawn spoked chariot."

MAINS USE

Build a three-step distinction: presence, centrality and technology package.

MINI RECAP

Species, context, chronology and wheel form must all match.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

HORSE, EQUID AND CHARIOT: THREE DISTINCT CLAIMS

- > KEYWORDS: equid identification; context; ashva; ratha; spoked wheel; solid wheel
- > ANSWER LINE: An equid bone does not prove horse centrality, and a solid-wheel vehicle does not become a light spoked war chariot.
- > RECAP: Species, context, chronology and wheel form must all match.

SESSION 11 - HARAPPAN TO LATE HARAPPAN TRANSFORMATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

The post-urban transition was a regionally varied reorganisation with continuity, movement and localisation rather than a civilisation-wide invasion destruction.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Institutional and urban discontinuity coexisted with demographic and cultural continuity.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

deurbanisation; localisation; continuity; regionalisation; settlement shift; no massacre horizon

VISUAL FIRST

MATURE URBAN INTEGRATION c.2600-1900 BCE

- |
- +-- city contraction / script-seal decline
- +-- regional pottery and settlement shifts
- +-- diversified crops and rural expansion
- `-- continued populations and practices

CORE TEACHING

The Mature Harappan system declined unevenly. Cities, script, standard weights and long-distance integration weakened, while late regional traditions, rural settlements, diversified agriculture and selected craft practices continued. Chronologies vary by site.

The old invasion model is contradicted by the absence of a civilisation-wide battle or destruction horizon. Mohenjo-daro skeletons do not form one massacre event, and Cemetery H is separated from Mature levels by contextual problems. This archaeological rejection of mass destruction does not prove zero migration in later centuries.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** Upinder Singh's OCR text at local PDF pp. 520-525 rejects the Wheeler massacre interpretation and describes regionally varied Late Harappan continuity; R.S. Sharma likewise separates movement from mass confrontation.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappan decline cannot be used as a proxy battle for Aryan origins. Archaeology shows uneven urban contraction, settlement movement and continued regional traditions rather than one assault horizon. This refutes a mass invasion destroying the civilisation. It remains compatible with later, smaller or multi-phase mobility interacting with post-Harappan populations.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: No mass invasion is not the same proposition as no migration.

MAINS USE

Use the phrase "institutional discontinuity with demographic and cultural continuity."

MINI RECAP

Harappan transformation preceded and overlapped later mobility without a universal destruction event.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

HARAPPAN TO LATE HARAPPAN TRANSFORMATION

- > KEYWORDS: deurbanisation; localisation; continuity; regionalisation; settlement shift; no massacre horizon
- > ANSWER LINE: Institutional and urban discontinuity coexisted with demographic and cultural continuity.
- > RECAP: Harappan transformation preceded and overlapped later mobility without a universal destruction event.

SESSION 12 - ARCHAEOLOGICAL CULTURES ARE NOT PEOPLES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

An archaeological culture is a recurring material assemblage defined by researchers, not a self-declared language or ethnicity.

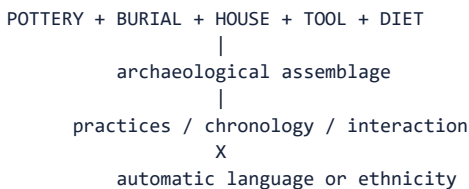
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Pots, burials and tools map practices and networks; they do not speak a language.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

assemblage; type-site; distribution; mortuary practice; ethnicity; one-to-one fallacy

VISUAL FIRST



CORE TEACHING

Material traits can spread through trade, imitation, mobility, marriage, specialist networks and prestige. One language can occur across several assemblages, and one assemblage can include multilingual communities.

Therefore Late Harappan, Cemetery H, Gandhara Grave/Swat, OCP, copper hoards, PGW, BMAC and Sintashta are useful contexts, not ethnic labels. Correlation becomes stronger only where chronology, geography and independent linguistic or textual evidence align.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** The canonical Basic owner explicitly rejects Cemetery H = Aryans, PGW = all Vedic people and BMAC = an Indo-Iranian nation.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Archaeology supplies indispensable chronology and material context but cannot automatically identify Vedic Sanskrit speakers. Cemetery H or PGW may overlap relevant transitions, and Swat or BMAC may illuminate interaction corridors. Similar artefacts can move without whole populations, while language can spread without uniform material replacement. The correct formulation is association with explicit alternatives, not identity.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Never write one culture = one people = one language.

MAINS USE

Use "associated with", "overlaps with" and "may reflect contact".

MINI RECAP

Assemblages identify patterns of practice, not named ethnic communities.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

ARCHAEOLOGICAL CULTURES ARE NOT PEOPLES

- > KEYWORDS: assemblage; type-site; distribution; mortuary practice; ethnicity; one-to-one fallacy
- > ANSWER LINE: Pots, burials and tools map practices and networks; they do not speak a language.
- > RECAP: Assemblages identify patterns of practice, not named ethnic communities.

SESSION 13 - CEMETERY H, SWAT, OCP AND PGW

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

These regional horizons document post-Harappan change and interaction but differ in chronology, geography and evidentiary value.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The proposed correlates form no single archaeological package and must be compared trait by trait.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Cemetery H; Gandhara Grave; Swat; OCP; copper hoards; PGW

VISUAL FIRST

CEMETERY H: mortuary change + continuity
SWAT/GANDHARA: long frontier sequence + varied burials
OCP/COPPER HOARDS: doab horizon + weak contexts
PGW: later Vedic/early Iron Age comparison
RULE: overlap/contact != ethnic identity

CORE TEACHING

Cemetery H shows pottery continuity with changed mortuary practice, including urn burials in later levels. Swat/Gandhara Grave spans a long period and varied burial customs; this breadth defeats a single-event migrant label. OCP overlaps Late Harappan at some sites, while many copper hoards lack secure stratigraphic context. PGW is mainly a later Vedic/early Iron Age comparison and is often only a small share of pottery.

Bhagwanpura is useful because Late Harappan and PGW materials occur in a sequence or overlap, but even here the evidence shows contact and change, not the language of each household.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** Upinder Singh's discussions of Late Harappan overlaps, PGW and Gandhara Grave chronology support regional, non-ethnic reading.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Post-Harappan archaeological horizons are evidence of regional transformation rather than a single Aryan assemblage. Cemetery H combines continuity and mortuary change; Swat contains a long and internally varied frontier sequence; OCP and copper hoards have uneven associations; PGW fits later developments better than early Rigvedic origins. Together they support contact and change, but their differences prevent one people-label.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Do not merge Cemetery H, Swat, OCP and PGW into one migration horizon.

MAINS USE

Use a comparative matrix and end with the one-culture/one-language caution.

MINI RECAP

The horizons are plural, regionally sequenced and ethnically silent.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

CEMETERY H, SWAT, OCP AND PGW

- > KEYWORDS: Cemetery H; Gandhara Grave; Swat; OCP; copper hoards; PGW
- > ANSWER LINE: The proposed correlates form no single archaeological package and must be compared trait by trait.
- > RECAP: The horizons are plural, regionally sequenced and ethnically silent.

SESSION 14 - BMAC, SINTASHTA AND INTERACTION CORRIDORS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

BMAC and Sintashta are distinct Bronze Age worlds connected through mobility, exchange and technological interaction.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A corridor model is stronger than a marching-arrow model because it allows borrowing, intermarriage and multi-stage movement.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

BMAC; Sintashta-Petrovka; oasis; steppe; metallurgy; corridor

VISUAL FIRST

```
STEPPE / SINTASHTA
    <---- mobility + technology ---->
    BMAC OASIS NETWORKS
    <---- exchange + ritual ---->
    IRAN / HINDU KUSH / SWAT / NW SOUTH ASIA
```

CORE TEACHING

Sintashta-Petrovka sites east of the Urals include fortified settlements, metallurgy, horse remains and early spoked-wheel vehicle burials. BMAC was an oasis-centred Central Asian world with settlements, craft and ritual evidence. Mobile steppe groups interacted with these communities.

Several models place Indo-Iranian linguistic dispersal within this broader interaction field. Yet BMAC was not simply an Indo-Iranian colony, and chariot technology can diffuse without language. The route from Central Asia to South Asia should be treated as a network of nodes, not a single military expedition.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** The canonical Basic and Advanced owners present BMAC as an interaction zone and Sintashta as an important but non-self-sufficient model component.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

BMAC and Sintashta contribute different pieces to an interaction model. Sintashta provides a dated technological and mobile-pastoral context, while BMAC supplies oasis networks linking steppe, Iran and the Hindu Kush. Their contact can explain borrowing and staged movement. Neither archaeological complex independently proves Indo-Aryan language, so the corridor remains a historically plausible synthesis rather than a traced itinerary.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Do not label BMAC "the Indo-Iranians" or treat Sintashta technology as direct language proof.

MAINS USE

Replace a single invasion arrow with connected zones and mechanisms.

MINI RECAP

Networks explain movement better than a one-stage ethnic package.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

BMAC, SINTASHTA AND INTERACTION CORRIDORS

-> KEYWORDS: BMAC; Sintashta-Petrovka; oasis; steppe; metallurgy; corridor

-> ANSWER LINE: A corridor model is stronger than a marching-arrow model because it allows borrowing, intermarriage and multi-stage movement.

-> RECAP: Networks explain movement better than a one-stage ethnic package.

SESSION 15 - COMPETING MODELS AND EVIDENTIARY STANDARDS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Invasion, migration, indigenous-continuity and interaction models must be judged by how many independent facts they explain with the fewest forced equations.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The strongest broad model combines movement with local continuity and rejects both conquest caricature and purity narratives.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

invasion; migration; indigenous continuity; out-of-India; interaction; falsifiability

VISUAL FIRST

MASS INVASION -> fails destruction/chronology test

ZERO MOVEMENT -> struggles with branching/Mitanni/aDNA

MIGRATION ONLY -> risks erasing local continuity

INTERACTION MODEL -> mobility + mixture + language shift + regional adaptation

CORE TEACHING

A violent mass invasion model implies sudden conquest, destruction and broad population replacement; the archaeological record does not support it. A strict no-inward-movement or maximal Out-of-India model must explain Indo-European branching, Indo-Iranian innovations, Mitanni chronology, interaction corridors and later Steppe-related ancestry.

A migration model should specify scale, tempo, route, social mechanism and chronology. An interaction model integrates mobility with local continuity, bilingualism, alliance, marriage, exchange and regional adaptation. It becomes empty only if these mechanisms remain unspecified.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** R.S. Sharma allows successive small movements rather than overwhelming conquest; Upinder Singh rejects the Harappan-destruction invasion while treating migration and interaction as open interdisciplinary questions.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The competing models are not equally supported. A mass invasion fails because no uniform destruction horizon links Harappan decline to a conquering population. A strict zero-movement model must overcome linguistic branching, Mitanni and later ancestry evidence. Multi-phase migration plus interaction explains more: it allows mobility and language spread while preserving large local demographic and cultural continuities. Exact routes and mechanisms remain debated.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Migration is not synonymous with invasion, empire or replacement.

MAINS USE

Compare models by prediction, evidence fit and unresolved residuals.

MINI RECAP

Movement plus interaction is the strongest broad synthesis, not a final detailed map.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

COMPETING MODELS AND EVIDENTIARY STANDARDS

- > KEYWORDS: invasion; migration; indigenous continuity; out-of-India; interaction; falsifiability
- > ANSWER LINE: The strongest broad model combines movement with local continuity and rejects both conquest caricature and purity narratives.
- > RECAP: Movement plus interaction is the strongest broad synthesis, not a final detailed map.

SESSION 16 - ARCHAEOGENETICS: WHAT THE METHOD MEASURES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Ancient DNA estimates biological relationships and mixture in dated samples; it does not recover language, religion or self-identity.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Report sample, date, place, sex, context, model and limitation before translating ancestry into history.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

ancient DNA; ancestry component; admixture; reference population; contamination; representativeness

VISUAL FIRST

SKELETON + CONTEXT

- > authentication
- > genome / lineage
- > statistical reference model
- > ancestry inference
- > historical interpretation WITH LIMITS

CORE TEACHING

Ancient-DNA analysis depends on preservation, contamination control, sample authentication and statistical comparison with reference populations. "Steppe-related" or "Iranian-related" identifies affinity to sampled or modelled populations; neither term denotes a pure race.

Coverage is uneven. Cemeteries may represent selected communities, male and female histories can differ, and a few individuals cannot stand for a whole civilisation. Admixture dates are modelled ranges. Language association remains an inference made through convergence with linguistics and chronology.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** Shinde et al. 2019 and Narasimhan et al. 2019 are peer-reviewed studies; both must be read through sample and model limits rather than headline labels.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Archaeogenetics can identify ancestry affinities and mixture in particular dated individuals, thereby testing whether population movement is plausible. Its evidentiary strength lies in direct biological sampling. Preservation, regional gaps, cemetery selection and reference-model dependence limit representativeness. Above all, DNA cannot encode Vedic Sanskrit or *arya* identity, so linguistic attribution remains a separate historical inference.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: There is no "Aryan gene"; ancestry components are statistical relationships.

MAINS USE

Use a method box before discussing any genetic result.

MINI RECAP

Genes reveal sampled ancestry, not language or civilisation.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

ARCHAEOGENETICS: WHAT THE METHOD MEASURES

- > KEYWORDS: ancient DNA; ancestry component; admixture; reference population; contamination; representativeness
- > ANSWER LINE: Report sample, date, place, sex, context, model and limitation before translating ancestry into history.
- > RECAP: Genes reveal sampled ancestry, not language or civilisation.

SESSION 17 - RAKHIGARHI: SHINDE ET AL. 2019

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

The published Rakhigarhi result is one Mature Harappan individual whose ancestry profile constrains, but cannot represent, the entire civilisation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Rakhigarhi is strongest for the sampled individual and weakest when inflated into a language or all-Harappan verdict.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Shinde et al.; Cell 2019; one individual; Steppe pastoralist; Iranian-related; sample limit

VISUAL FIRST

ONE RAKHIGARHI INDIVIDUAL

- > no detectable Steppe pastoralist ancestry in that profile
- > Iranian-related ancestry not equal recent Iranian farmer migration
- > IMPORTANT chronological constraint
- > NOT Harappan language / all sites / all later periods

CORE TEACHING

Shinde et al., "An Ancient Harappan Genome Lacks Ancestry from Steppe Pastoralists or Iranian Farmers," appeared in *Cell* in 2019 (DOI 10.1016/j.cell.2019.08.048). The sampled individual lacked detectable Steppe-pastoralist ancestry. The title's "Iranian farmers" must not be simplified: the Iranian-related ancestry was from a deeper lineage distinct from sampled western agriculturalists.

The study cannot identify Harappan language or represent every region, class, sex or phase. Absence in one individual constrains Mature Harappan ancestry at that context; it cannot rule out later second-millennium movement.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** Peer-reviewed *Cell* paper, 2019, one directly sampled Harappan individual; exact sample size and publication date are stated.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The Rakhigarhi genome is an important chronological constraint, not a civilisational identity certificate. The sampled Mature Harappan individual lacked detectable Steppe-pastoralist ancestry and carried an Iranian-related component distinct from recent western farmers. This weighs against projecting later Steppe ancestry into that person. One genome cannot establish the language of Harappans or exclude later movement into other regions.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Absence of Steppe-related ancestry in one Harappan sample does not mean absence of later migration.

MAINS USE

Always write "one published individual" and name what the result cannot establish.

MINI RECAP

Rakhigarhi constrains a context; it does not close population or language history.

RAKHIGARHI: SHINDE ET AL. 2019

-> ANSWER LINE: Rakhigarhi is strongest for the sampled individual and weakest when inflated into a language or all-Harappan verdict.

SESSION 18 - NARASIMHAN ET AL. 2019 AND LATER STEPPE-RELATED ANCESTRY

The broader dataset supports post-Harappan Steppe-related ancestry movement, while the language link remains a convergence argument rather than a genetic observation.

Page 22

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

NARASIMHAN ET AL. 2019 AND LATER STEPPE-RELATED ANCESTRY

-> KEYWORDS: Narasimhan et al.; Science 2019; 523 individuals; Steppe_MLBA-related; admixture; convergence

-> ANSWER LINE: The broader dataset supports post-Harappan Steppe-related ancestry movement, while the language link remains a convergence argument rather than a genetic observation.

-> RECAP: The broad dataset supports movement plus mixture, not racial replacement.

SESSION 19 - IDENTITY FORMATION: ACCULTURATION, BILINGUALISM AND MIXTURE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Early Indo-Aryan cultural identity was historically produced through interaction rather than preserved as a sealed package.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The relevant outcome was cultural formation through movement, borrowing and local incorporation, not simple replacement.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

acculturation; bilingualism; substrate; loanword; intermarriage; ethnogenesis

VISUAL FIRST

MOBILITY + LOCAL CONTINUITY

- + bilingualism / prestige shift
- + marriage / alliance / conflict
- + borrowed crops, words and practices
- = regionally formed early Vedic identities

CORE TEACHING

The Rig Veda contains non-Indo-European words and names, while contact linguistics discusses substrate vocabulary and retroflexion as South Asian areal features. Exact donor languages and dates may be disputed, but contact itself is difficult to deny.

Language can spread through demographic movement, elite networks, pastoral mobility, bilingualism and intermarriage without complete population replacement. Local crops, places, technologies, ritual forms and communities could be incorporated. Identity boundaries such as *arya* and *dasa* could shift through alliance and status.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** Upinder Singh notes non-Indo-Aryan words and names in the corpus; the canonical owner treats retroflexion and loanwords as contact evidence with attribution cautions.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The identity represented in early Vedic texts was formed through interaction. Non-Indo-European vocabulary and names, areal phonological features and mixed political relations indicate contact with existing South Asian communities. Such evidence explains how an Indo-Aryan language could spread while large local ancestries and practices continued. The exact donor languages and mechanisms remain debated, so acculturation should be described as a process, not a uniform event.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Language shift can occur without total demographic replacement.

MAINS USE

Use identity formation to move beyond invasion-versus-no-migration binaries.

MINI RECAP

Early Vedic identity was relational, mixed and regionally formed.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

IDENTITY FORMATION: ACCULTURATION, BILINGUALISM AND MIXTURE

- > KEYWORDS: acculturation; bilingualism; substrate; loanword; intermarriage; ethnogenesis
- > ANSWER LINE: The relevant outcome was cultural formation through movement, borrowing and local incorporation, not simple replacement.
- > RECAP: Early Vedic identity was relational, mixed and regionally formed.

SESSION 20 - FACTS, INTERPRETATIONS AND UNRESOLVED QUESTIONS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

A disciplined answer labels high-confidence facts, reasonable interpretations and unresolved questions separately.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

State what is secure, what is inferred and what remains unknown; neutrality is precision, not false equivalence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

fact; interpretation; unresolved; confidence; alternative; uncertainty

VISUAL FIRST

SECURE

language family; no mass Harappan assault; sample-specific DNA

INTERPRETIVE

routes; social mechanism; culture-language correlations

UNRESOLVED

Harappan language; exact Rigvedic layers; migration scale/tempo

CORE TEACHING

Secure ground includes the linguistic position of Vedic Sanskrit, the invalidity of Aryan as a biological race, the broad chronological priority of Mature Harappan urbanism, the lack of a universal invasion destruction horizon and the mixed formation of South Asian populations.

Reasonable synthesis includes multi-phase movement of some Indo-Aryan-speaking groups and cultural formation through interaction. Unresolved questions include precise homeland and routes, the scale and sex composition of movements, exact dating of Rigvedic layers, Harappan language and detailed correlations among BMAC, Swat and South Asian horizons.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** The canonical Core owner explicitly separates high-confidence ground, reasonable synthesis and debated questions.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

A balanced conclusion need not pretend that all positions are equal. Linguistic relationship and the rejection of biological race are secure; migration-and-interaction is the strongest broad synthesis; exact routes, social mechanisms and Harappan language remain unresolved. This graded structure demonstrates neutrality because each proposition receives confidence proportional to its evidence, not because every ideological claim receives equal space.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Balanced does not mean refusing a verdict or treating unsupported claims as co-equal.

MAINS USE

Use a three-tier conclusion: secure, probable and unresolved.

MINI RECAP

Evidence-aware neutrality ranks claims and displays uncertainty.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

FACTS, INTERPRETATIONS AND UNRESOLVED QUESTIONS

- > KEYWORDS: fact; interpretation; unresolved; confidence; alternative; uncertainty
- > ANSWER LINE: State what is secure, what is inferred and what remains unknown; neutrality is precision, not false equivalence.
- > RECAP: Evidence-aware neutrality ranks claims and displays uncertainty.

SESSION 21 - POLITICAL MISUSE AND ANSWER NEUTRALITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Presentism projects modern racial, national, caste or religious identities onto ancient evidence whose categories were different.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Ancient movement or continuity cannot confer modern ownership, purity or political legitimacy.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

presentism; essentialism; ownership claim; purity; nationalism; source ethics

VISUAL FIRST

ANCIENT TERM / POT / BONE / GENOME
|
historical interpretation
X
modern racial-national-religious entitlement

CORE TEACHING

Colonial racialism, nationalist reaction and contemporary political mobilisation can all turn uncertain ancient evidence into claims of superiority, indigeneity or exclusion. Genetics is especially vulnerable to misuse because statistical ancestry labels can be mistaken for named peoples.

The correct response is not to hide evidence but to disclose category, date, sample and inference. Migration does not make a population culturally foreign forever; continuity does not imply unchanged identity; and neither establishes rights in the present.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** The topic's historiography and source matrix show repeated misuse when language, ancestry and culture are collapsed.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Political misuse begins when an ancient analytical category is converted into a modern entitlement. Colonial writers racialised a language family, while presentist arguments may treat pottery or genomes as certificates of national purity. Historical method counters both by dating evidence, separating categories and acknowledging mixture. The conclusion should be explicit: ancient mobility and continuity explain formation; they do not allocate modern legitimacy.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: Do not turn a historical conclusion into a civilisational loyalty test.

MAINS USE

Add one sentence on presentism only after the evidence has been evaluated.

MINI RECAP

Method protects history from both colonial and nationalist essentialism.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

POLITICAL MISUSE AND ANSWER NEUTRALITY

- > KEYWORDS: presentism; essentialism; ownership claim; purity; nationalism; source ethics
- > ANSWER LINE: Ancient movement or continuity cannot confer modern ownership, purity or political legitimacy.
- > RECAP: Method protects history from both colonial and nationalist essentialism.

SESSION 22 - SOURCE-CRITICISM ANSWER FRAMEWORK

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

A high-scoring answer converts each source into a bounded claim and ends with a calibrated synthesis.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Write claim -> named evidence -> what it establishes -> alternative -> limit, then compare the models.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

directive; category firewall; evidence matrix; qualification; model comparison; verdict

VISUAL FIRST

DEFINE categories

- > ORDER chronology
- > TEST linguistics
- > LOCATE textual geography
- > COMPARE archaeology
- > BOUND genetics
- > WEIGH models
- > CONCLUDE: movement + continuity + interaction

CORE TEACHING

For 10 marks, define the category, use three evidence classes and state one limit for each. For 15 marks, add model comparison and a named archaeological or genetic case. For 20 marks, begin with historiography, organise an evidence matrix, separate Rakhigarhi from wider aDNA, address political misuse and conclude through secure/probable/unresolved tiers.

Do not dump site names. Each paragraph must show what evidence proves and what it cannot prove. A map or chronology strip adds value only when it supports an argument.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

FACT: **Fact:** The source hierarchy, canonical answer architecture and routed-PYQ audit jointly support an evidence-weighting rather than slogan-based answer.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

A defensible answer first defines *arya* and Indo-Aryan, then orders Harappan, Central Asian, Mitanni and Rigvedic chronologies. It uses linguistics for relationship, text for a bounded cultural world, archaeology for material sequences and genetics for sampled ancestry. By testing invasion, migration and indigenous-continuity models against these categories, it can favour migration and interaction while preserving unresolved routes and identities.

UPSC TRAP

WRONG: A site list without inference and qualification is not analysis.

MAINS USE

This is the executable structure for any 10-, 15- or 20-mark question.

MINI RECAP

Define, date, triangulate, qualify and conclude by confidence.

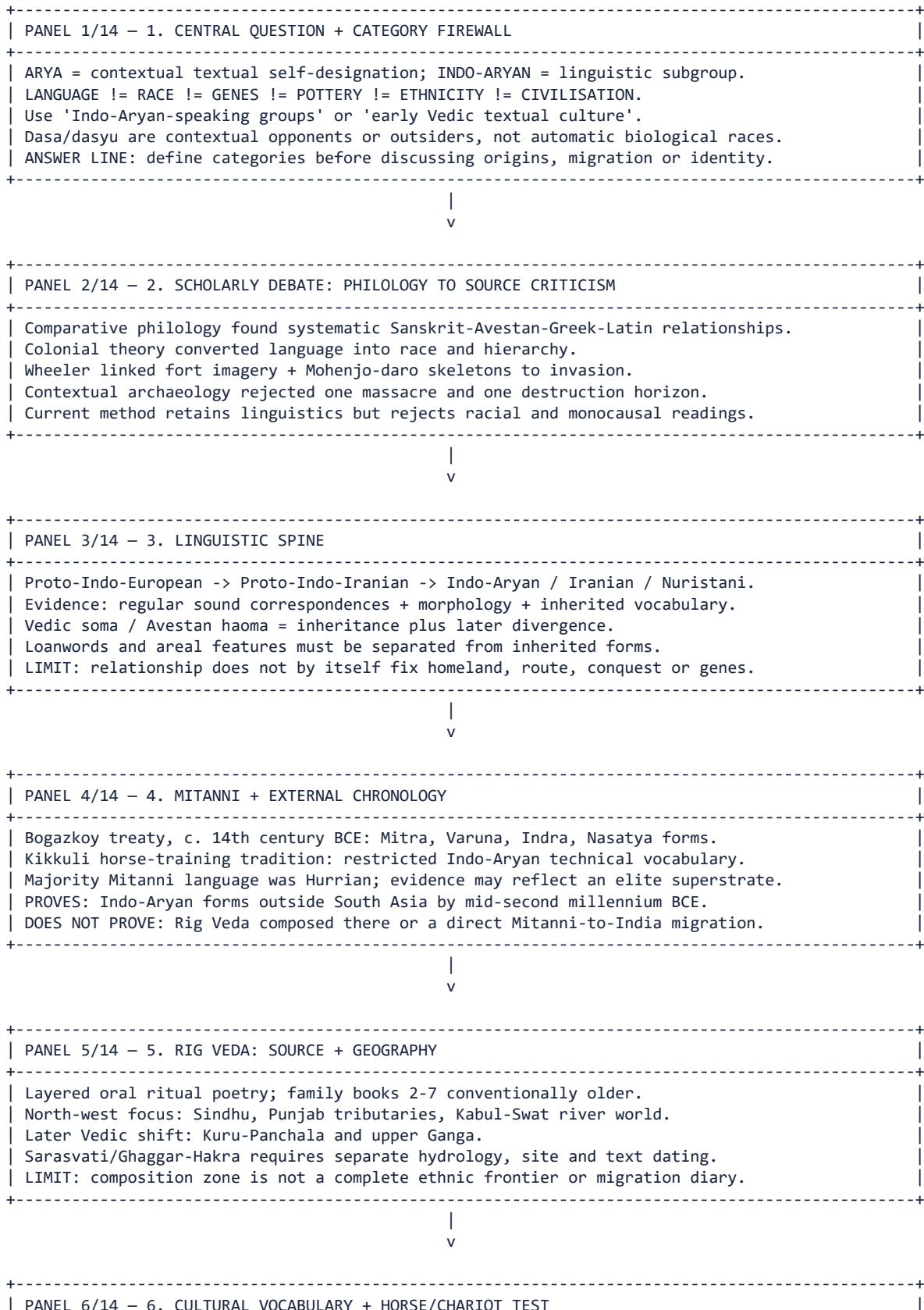
CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SOURCE-CRITICISM ANSWER FRAMEWORK

-> KEYWORDS: directive; category firewall; evidence matrix; qualification; model comparison; verdict
-> ANSWER LINE: Write claim -> named evidence -> what it establishes -> alternative -> limit, then compare the models.
-> RECAP: Define, date, triangulate, qualify and conclude by confidence.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

THE ARYAN PROBLEM AND IDENTITY OF ARYAN CULTURE – ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM



+-----+
 | Cattle wealth + pasture + raids coexist with ploughing, wells and harvesting.
 | Balanced phrase: pastoral predominance within an agro-pastoral economy.
 | Equid bone -> species/context; horse -> frequency/use; vehicle -> wheel/form/draught.
 | Surkotada equid debated; Harappan carts solid-wheel; Sanauli vehicles solid-wheel.
 | Sintashta spoked-wheel evidence and Mitanni vocabulary are convergent, not decisive.
 +-----+

|
 v

+-----+
 | PANEL 7/14 – 7. HARAPPAN TO POST-HARAPPAN TRANSFORMATION
 +-----+
 | Mature Harappan c.2600-1900 BCE largely precedes conventional Rigvedic horizon.
 | Late phase: city contraction + localisation + rural expansion + crop diversity.
 | No civilisation-wide military assault; Mohenjo-daro skeletons are not one massacre.
 | Cemetery H contains continuity plus mortuary change, not a named migrant people.
 | FORMULA: institutional discontinuity with demographic and cultural continuity.
 +-----+

|
 v

+-----+
 | PANEL 8/14 – 8. ARCHAEOLOGICAL CORRELATES WITHOUT ETHNIC LABELS
 +-----+
 | Swat/Gandhara Grave = long varied frontier sequence, not one invasion event.
 | OCP/copper hoards = uneven associations; many hoards have weak provenance.
 | PGW = later Vedic/early Iron Age comparison, not early Rigvedic ethnicity.
 | Bhagwanpura overlap shows sequence/contact; it does not identify household language.
 | RULE: culture labels map assemblages; objects can move through many mechanisms.
 +-----+

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 v

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 | PANEL 9/14 – 9. BMAC-SINTASHTA CORRIDOR
 +-----+
 | Sintashta: fortified sites, metallurgy, horses and early spoked-wheel vehicles.
 | BMAC: Central Asian oasis settlements, craft and ritual networks.
 | Steppe <-> oasis <-> Iran/Hindu Kush/Swat/NW South Asia interaction.
 | Mobility can be repeated, household-scale, gender-skewed and network-mediated.
 | LIMIT: neither BMAC nor Sintashta independently proves Indo-Aryan language.
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 | PANEL 10/14 – 10. COMPETING MODELS
 +-----+
 | Mass invasion: fails uniform destruction and replacement predictions.
 | Strict zero movement: must explain branching, Mitanni and later ancestry evidence.
 | Migration only: incomplete if it erases local continuity and acculturation.
 | Best broad model: multi-phase movement + interaction + admixture + regional formation.
 | UNRESOLVED: exact route, scale, tempo, gender balance and political mechanism.
 +-----+

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 v

+-----+
 | PANEL 11/14 – 11. ARCHAEOGENETIC METHOD
 +-----+
 | Sample + archaeological context -> authentication -> genome -> statistical model.
 | Steppe-related and Iranian-related are affinities, not pure peoples.
 | Check date, region, sex, burial selection, contamination and reference choice.
 | Admixture dates are ranges; one cemetery is not a population census.
 | GENES cannot directly identify language, religion, caste or self-designation.
 +-----+

|
 v

+-----+
 | PANEL 12/14 – 12. RAKHIGARHI + NARASIMHAN 2019
 +-----+
 | Shinde et al., Cell 2019: one Rakhigarhi individual; no detectable Steppe ancestry.
 | Its Iranian-related ancestry was not simple recent western-farmer ancestry.
 +-----+

Narasimhan et al., Science 2019: 523 ancient individuals across a wider region. Supports later Steppe-related movement + extensive IVC-related continuity/mixture. LIMIT: consistency with language spread is not direct genetic proof of language.	
	 v
PANEL 13/14 – 13. IDENTITY FORMATION + POLITICAL MISUSE	
Movement + bilingualism + marriage + alliance/conflict + borrowing -> ethnogenesis. Non-Indo-European words/names and areal features support contact in South Asia. Migration does not imply permanent foreignness; continuity does not imply purity. Ancient genes, pots and terms cannot allocate modern ownership or legitimacy. Neutrality = transparent categories and evidence weights, not false equivalence.	
	 v
PANEL 14/14 – 14. PYQ ROUTE + ANSWER SPINE + VERDICT	
Direct routed Aryan-origin/migration PYQs, 2018-2026: ZERO. Adjacent routes: 2023/2024 Vedic Mains; 2026 vocabulary/geography Prelims. WRITE: define -> chronology -> linguistics -> text -> archaeology -> genetics. Then compare models -> secure/probable/unresolved -> qualified conclusion. VERDICT: movement and interaction are likely; race and one-culture equations fail.	

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D, repeated eight times. All 128 option explanations and 32 traps are question-specific.

Q1

1 Which formulation is methodologically safest?

- A. Arya is contextual, while Indo-Aryan is a linguistic category.
- B. Aryan denotes a biological race visible in skeletons.
- C. Indo-Aryan denotes one pottery assemblage.
- D. Arya denotes every Indo-European speaker.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: it preserves the distinction between textual self-designation and linguistic classification. [Q1-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Race cannot be read from the word *arya*. [Q1-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Language does not equal pottery. [Q1-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: The textual term is narrower than the whole language family. [Q1-D]

Examiner trap 1: Separate textual identity from language and biology.

Q2

2 In Rigvedic usage, *arya* is best understood as

- A. a fixed skin-colour category
- B. a contextual insider or status designation
- C. the name of a single archaeological culture
- D. a genetic ancestry component

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The texts do not supply a stable phenotype definition. [Q2-A]
- **B:** Correct: usage varies by passage, alliance and ritual-political context. [Q2-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Archaeological cultures are modern analytical groupings. [Q2-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Genetic components are statistical and modern analytical labels. [Q2-D]

Examiner trap 2: Read *arya* by context, not as a timeless race.

Q3

3 Which colonial-era move created the central racial distortion?

- A. Treating the whole Rigvedic corpus as a late and internally uniform composition
- B. Rejecting every comparison with Avestan
- C. Converting linguistic relationship into biological hierarchy
- D. Dating PGW before the Mature Harappan phase

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Textual dating debate is not the defining racial conversion. [Q3-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Avestan comparison was central to philology. [Q3-B]
- **C:** Correct: speech history was transformed into a superior racial type. [Q3-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: The chronology is wrong but is not the core historiographical move. [Q3-D]

Examiner trap 3: The valid linguistic discovery must be separated from racial typology.

Q4

4 Comparative linguistics establishes Indo-European relationship chiefly through

- A. a small cluster of similar divine names and isolated lexical resemblances across texts
- B. modern national boundaries
- C. a shared pottery style
- D. regular sound correspondences, grammar and inherited vocabulary

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: A single resemblance may be accidental or borrowed. [Q4-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Modern borders are irrelevant to prehistoric language descent. [Q4-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Material style cannot demonstrate phonological descent. [Q4-C]
- **D:** Correct: repeated structural correspondences support genealogical relationship. [Q4-D]

Examiner trap 4: Patterns, not isolated word resemblance, establish language descent.

Q5

5 Vedic Sanskrit belongs to which nested sequence?

- A. Indo-Aryan -> Indo-Iranian -> Indo-European
- B. Iranian -> Indo-Aryan -> Indo-European, treating Iranian as the parent branch
- C. Indo-European -> Dravidian -> Indo-Aryan
- D. BMAC -> Indo-Iranian -> Vedic Sanskrit

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: this is the accepted linguistic hierarchy. [Q5-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Iranian and Indo-Aryan are sister developments, not parent and child. [Q5-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Dravidian is a distinct language family. [Q5-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: BMAC is archaeological, not a linguistic parent. [Q5-D]

Examiner trap 5: Keep linguistic branches separate from archaeological complexes.

Q6

6 The Mitanni evidence most securely demonstrates

- A. that the Rig Veda was composed in Syria
- B. restricted Indo-Aryan forms outside South Asia by the mid-second millennium BCE
- C. that all Mitanni people spoke Vedic Sanskrit
- D. a direct military migration from Mitanni to Punjab

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: External attestation does not locate Rigvedic composition. [Q6-A]
- **B:** Correct: treaty names and technical vocabulary provide bounded external attestation. [Q6-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Hurrian was the majority language. [Q6-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No direct route or military event follows from the texts. [Q6-D]

Examiner trap 6: Mitanni adds chronology, not a complete route.

Q7

7 Which evidence-class pairing is correct?

- A. Genetics - spoken language of a sampled person
- B. Archaeology - self-declared ethnicity without inscriptions
- C. Comparative linguistics - language descent and contact
- D. Rigvedic poetry - exact census data

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: DNA does not record language. [Q7-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Objects do not self-identify ethnicity. [Q7-B]
- **C:** Correct: sound, grammar and vocabulary establish relationship and borrowing. [Q7-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Ritual poetry is not a statistical census. [Q7-D]

Examiner trap 7: Each evidence class has a different object.

Q8

8 Before combining two datasets, the first requirement is to

- A. assume they describe one people
- B. prefer the newest discipline and let it automatically override all earlier evidence classes
- C. discard contradictory results
- D. match chronology, geography, scale and independence

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Shared labels cannot substitute for proof. [Q8-A]

- **B:** Incorrect: Novelty does not determine evidentiary weight. [Q8-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Contradictions must be preserved and explained. [Q8-C]
- **D:** Correct: convergence is meaningful only after these controls. [Q8-D]

Examiner trap 8: Triangulation begins with compatibility, not fusion.

Q9

9 The Rig Veda is most accurately described as

- A. a layered ritual-poetic corpus with historical clues
- B. a securely dated royal chronicle recording successive rulers, battles and migrations
- C. an archaeological field report
- D. a complete census of early society

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: genre, oral transmission and layering define its use. [Q9-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It has no annalistic year-by-year structure. [Q9-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Material context must come from archaeology. [Q9-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Elite ritual poetry cannot enumerate the whole population. [Q9-D]

Examiner trap 9: Use the Rig Veda intensively but not literally.

Q10

10 Which statement about Sarasvati/Ghaggar-Hakra is best?

- A. Their identity proves Harappan language.
- B. Palaeochannel, occupation and textual chronology must be tested separately.
- C. a similar river name fixes a single migration route and synchronises Vedic and Harappan dates
- D. Every Harappan site belonged to one river system.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The Harappan script remains undeciphered. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct: hydrology, archaeology and textual layering are independent controls. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: A hydronym cannot establish one migration itinerary. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Harappan sites occupied several ecological zones. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: A palaeochannel is not automatically a named Vedic river.

Q11

11 Rigvedic economic vocabulary supports

- A. exclusive urban commerce
- B. complete nomadism without cultivation
- C. pastoral predominance within an agro-pastoral economy
- D. an iron-centred agrarian state

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The corpus does not depict Harappan-style urbanism. [Q11-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Ploughing, wells and harvest vocabulary contradict exclusive nomadism. [Q11-B]

- **C:** Correct: cattle-centred values coexist with cultivation and craft. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Early *ayas* should not be converted automatically into iron. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: Pastoral emphasis and agriculture can coexist.

Q12

12 In an early Rigvedic context, *ayas* should

- A. always be translated as iron and used to assign every hymn to an iron-using agrarian society
- B. be ignored because texts are oral
- C. prove PGW identity
- D. be treated cautiously, often within a copper/bronze material world

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Iron-centred development is later and regionally variable. [Q12-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Oral texts remain valuable with source criticism. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: A word cannot identify a pottery assemblage. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct: translation depends on context and chronology. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: Do not back-project later iron into every early reference.

Q13

13 Which sequence correctly handles horse/chariot evidence?

- A. species -> context -> frequency/use -> vehicle form -> chronology
- B. horse terminology and ritual prominence directly prove one invasion and its military mechanism
- C. solid wheel -> light spoked chariot
- D. equid fragment -> ethnic identity

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: every inferential step must be demonstrated. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Textual importance does not prove a military event. [Q13-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Wheel construction is a decisive distinction. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Animal identification cannot establish ethnicity. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: Presence, centrality and technology are separate claims.

Q14

14 Surkotada is used cautiously because

- A. it has a deciphered horse inscription
- B. equid species identification and wider significance remain debated
- C. it contains a secure Sintashta chariot
- D. it proves horses were absent throughout South Asia before later second-millennium movements

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: No deciphered Harappan inscription supplies that label. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct: morphology, context and representativeness remain disputed. [Q14-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Sintashta is a separate steppe context. [Q14-C]

- **D:** Incorrect: A disputed find cannot prove universal absence. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: A debated equid is neither proof of centrality nor proof of absence.

Q15

15 Sintashta-Petrovka is important chiefly for

- A. a Harappan urban script
- B. solid-wheel carts in the upper Ganga plain that securely identify early Vedic-speaking migrants
- C. early second-millennium spoked-wheel vehicle contexts
- D. a direct Rigvedic manuscript

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It is not Harappan. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: That description fits neither location nor vehicle evidence. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct: chariot technology and metallurgy make it a key comparative horizon. [Q15-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No Rigvedic manuscript comes from the site. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: Technology strengthens a model but does not itself identify language.

Q16

16 The safest statement about Sanauli is that

- A. horse sacrifice is proven
- B. the burials are securely Vedic
- C. the vehicles are Sintashta-type spoked chariots
- D. two-wheeled solid-wheel vehicles occur; draught animal and identity remain unsettled

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: No horse remains securely establish the claim. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Burial identity cannot be read directly. [Q16-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: The vehicles have solid rather than demonstrated spoked wheels. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct: this distinguishes observation from interpretation. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: Media use of "chariot" must not erase wheel and draught evidence.

Q17

17 Which statement best fits Harappan decline?

- A. It was a regionally varied transformation with no civilisation-wide invasion horizon.
- B. It occurred through one massacre at Mohenjo-daro.
- C. It proves no later movement into South Asia.
- D. It was simultaneous at every site.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: urban contraction, localisation and continuity varied regionally. [Q17-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: The skeletons do not form one massacre context. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Rejection of invasion does not prove zero migration. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Site chronologies differ. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: Do not use Harappan decline as a shortcut verdict on later migration.

Q18

18 Cemetery H most usefully demonstrates

- A. a named Indo-Aryan tribe whose language and migration route can be read directly from its burials
- B. continuity with mortuary and material change
- C. a complete population replacement
- D. the language of Harappa

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Burial assemblages do not provide a self-name. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Correct: continuity and changed urn practices must be assessed together. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: The record does not show total replacement. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Harappan writing remains undeciphered. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: Mortuary change is not an ethnic label.

Q19

19 The Gandhara Grave/Swat evidence should be treated as

- A. one brief invasion event
- B. a uniform race marker
- C. a long, varied frontier interaction sequence
- D. a direct translation of Rigvedic burial rules

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Its broad chronology contradicts a single event. [Q19-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Burial practices do not define race. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct: varied rites and contacts make corridor analysis safer. [Q19-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Text and graves cannot be equated automatically. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: Chronological breadth defeats a one-wave interpretation.

Q20

20 OCP and copper hoards cannot be equated with Aryans mainly because

- A. copper was unknown in South Asia
- B. OCP occurs only in Central Asia
- C. all copper hoards are ritual deposits of one incoming community, irrespective of find context
- D. associations and contexts vary, while objects do not identify language

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Copper use is well attested. [Q20-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: OCP is associated with the upper Ganga-Yamuna region. [Q20-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Functions vary and many finds lack context. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct: heterogeneous context blocks an ethnic equation. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: An antennae sword is not a linguistic fossil.

Q21

21 Painted Grey Ware is best used as

- A. a later Vedic/early Iron Age archaeological comparison with regional limits
- B. the unique pottery of early Rigvedic migrants, allowing its distribution to map language spread
- C. proof that every PGW site used iron
- D. a Mature Harappan urban marker

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: its chronology and geography fit later transformations better. [Q21-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: PGW cannot identify speakers and is generally later. [Q21-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Some PGW contexts lack iron. [Q21-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It post-dates Mature Harappan urbanism. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: PGW is a correlate, not "the Aryans".

Q22

22 BMAC is best understood as

- A. a single Indo-Iranian nation
- B. an oasis interaction world linked with mobile groups
- C. a Harappan colony
- D. a genetic ancestry component

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Archaeology cannot supply that national-language identity. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct: settlement, craft and ritual networks interacted with steppe groups. [Q22-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: No evidence supports simple colonial identity. [Q22-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: BMAC names an archaeological complex, not DNA. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: Use BMAC as a network node, not a conveyor belt.

Q23

23 Why can archaeology not identify Vedic Sanskrit speakers by itself?

- A. Sites have no chronology.
- B. Pottery cannot be classified.
- C. Material assemblages spread by varied mechanisms and do not directly record speech.
- D. texts are always more accurate than objects and can assign speech to any contemporary assemblage

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Archaeological chronology is often strong. [Q23-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Classification is possible but remains analytical. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct: trade, imitation, marriage and mobility break one-to-one mapping. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Texts and objects answer different questions; neither is automatically superior. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: An assemblage is not a language community.

Q24

24 A migration model differs from an invasion model because migration

- A. excludes conflict
- B. requires no movement
- C. always means elite dominance by male warrior bands and excludes household or pastoral mobility
- D. can be gradual, multi-phase and compatible with local continuity

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Conflict may occur without defining the whole process. [Q24-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Migration necessarily involves mobility. [Q24-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Several social mechanisms are possible. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Correct: movement need not be conquest or replacement. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: Do not make invasion and migration synonyms.

Q25

25 A rigorous indigenous/Out-of-India model must explain

- A. Indo-European branching, Indo-Iranian innovations, Mitanni and later ancestry evidence
- B. only Sarasvati identification, because one river match would settle homeland and chronology
- C. only cultural continuity
- D. only the absence of a massacre horizon

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: a full model must address all contrary evidence classes. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: One river claim cannot settle the family history. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Continuity does not determine language origin. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No massacre excludes mass invasion, not all mobility. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: A model is tested by the evidence it can explain, not by one favoured fact.

Q26

26 Ancient DNA can directly establish

- A. the language spoken by a skeleton when its ancestry matches a historically attested population
- B. ancestry relationships in a dated sampled individual
- C. the caste of a Bronze Age community
- D. the religious identity of a burial

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Language is not encoded in DNA. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct: this is the method's proper object. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Caste is historical and cannot be read directly from one genome. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Burial meaning needs cultural evidence. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: Ancestry is biological evidence with sample limits.

Q27

27 The strongest safe conclusion from the published Rakhigarhi genome is

- A. all Harappans lacked Steppe ancestry
- B. Harappans spoke a non-Indo-European language
- C. one sampled Mature Harappan lacked detectable Steppe-pastoralist ancestry
- D. no later Steppe-related movement occurred

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: One person cannot represent all Harappans. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Language was not recovered. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct: the claim is bounded by person, context and date. [Q27-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Later movement is a different chronological question. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: Always state "one published individual".

Q28

28 Narasimhan et al. 2019 is most accurately used to support

- A. a pure Aryan race
- B. one exact invasion date and route derived from modelled admixture estimates across all regions
- C. the language of every sampled individual
- D. later Steppe-related movement plus extensive IVC-related continuity and mixture

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The study rejects pure-race framing. [Q28-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Admixture is modelled over ranges. [Q28-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Genomes do not speak. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct: the regional dataset supports movement and mixture together. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: The study models population history, not an Aryan gene.

Q29

29 Absence of archaeological evidence is strongest when

- A. preservation, survey coverage and expected visibility are considered
- B. nothing has yet been excavated
- C. a text predicts an event
- D. one excavated site lacks an artefact expected from a text, regardless of regional preservation

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: patterned absence requires an expectation of survival and discovery. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Unsearched ground makes absence weak. [Q29-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Textual expectation does not create material evidence. [Q29-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: One local absence rarely supports a regional universal. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: Absence is evidence only after a visibility test.

Q30

30 Which process best explains early Vedic identity formation?

- A. complete replacement of local populations
- B. mobility combined with bilingualism, alliance, intermarriage and borrowing
- C. unchanged preservation of a sealed migrant culture without borrowing, intermarriage or adaptation
- D. one royal decree imposing language

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The evidence supports substantial local continuity. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct: several social mechanisms can spread language and practices. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Contact features contradict sealed preservation. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No such decree is known. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: Identity formed through interaction, not purity.

Q31

31 Which three-level conclusion is best?

- A. Every issue is unresolved.
- B. all linguistic, archaeological, textual and genetic evidence proves the same migration event
- C. Secure linguistic relationship; probable multi-phase movement; exact route and scale unresolved.
- D. One archaeological culture settles the debate.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Several conclusions are high-confidence. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Evidence classes have different objects. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct: this grades facts, interpretations and open questions. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No assemblage has that power. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: Neutrality ranks evidence rather than flattening it.

Q32

32 Which answer sequence is most defensible?

- A. Genetics -> race -> ownership claim
- B. Sarasvati -> Harappan language -> final verdict
- C. Horse bone -> invasion -> replacement
- D. define categories -> order chronology -> triangulate -> compare models -> qualify

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: This commits category and presentist errors. [Q32-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: River identification cannot decipher language. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: One faunal item cannot prove a military demographic event. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct: this sequence makes the reasoning auditable. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: A source-critical answer is an argument, not a slogan or catalogue.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AND KEY DISCIPLINE

Direct ownership audit: the repository's verified 2018-2026 routing ledgers contain **zero direct Aryan-origin or migration PYQs** for Topic 07. No question is relabelled to manufacture ownership.

Adjacent verified route	Status	Correct Topic 07 use
2026 Prelims Set A Q10 - Rigvedic irrigation, wells and draught power	Question verified; local key provisional, so no official answer letter claimed	Tests bounded material vocabulary, not migration
2026 Prelims Set A Q15 - Vedic river names	Question verified; local key provisional	Tests precise textual geography, not an ethnic map
2026 Prelims Set A Q20 - <i>Kshetra-patni</i>	Question verified; local key provisional	Tests vocabulary; no full cultural chronology follows
2023 GS-I Q11 - Vedic society, religion and persistence	Exact Mains question verified; UPSC publishes no official model answer	Cultural-profile route owned primarily by Topic 08
2024 GS-I Q1 - Rig-to-Later Vedic society and economy	Exact Mains question verified; UPSC publishes no official model answer	Transition route owned primarily by Topics 08-09

Key discipline: official wording and official answer keys are distinct. The three 2026 objective questions retain provisional-key status; no official option is asserted here. The two descriptive questions have instructional answer routes, never an "official model answer."

Adjacent Mains route - 2023 GS-I Q11

Verified wording: What are the main features of Vedic society and religion? Do you think some of the features are still prevailing in Indian society? (250 words, 15 marks.)

Topic 07 answer route: define the layered textual source; identify kinship, chiefly authority, pastoral-agricultural life, sacrifice and major deities; separate early from later Vedic traits; discuss only carefully qualified continuities. Do not convert the question into an Aryan-origin verdict.

Adjacent Mains route - 2024 GS-I Q1

Verified wording: Underline the changes in the field of society and economy from the Rig Vedic to the later Vedic period. (150 words, 10 marks.)

Topic 07 answer route: compare cattle-centred agro-pastoral life with more settled agrarian production, kin-based groups with territorial tendencies and fluid hierarchy with later hardening. Use PGW only as a qualified archaeological context, not as the ethnicity of Vedic speakers.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Why must *arya*, Indo-Aryan language and biological ancestry be kept analytically separate? (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (125 words):

The three terms answer different questions. In the Rig Veda, *arya* is a contextual self-designation linked to alliance, status and ritual-political belonging. Indo-Aryan is a linguistic subgroup established through regular correspondences with Iranian and wider Indo-European languages. Biological ancestry is reconstructed statistically from sampled genomes. None automatically identifies the others. Thus a PGW vessel cannot be called Indo-Aryan merely from its style, and one Rakhigarhi genome cannot establish Harappan language. The distinction also corrects colonial race theory, which converted linguistic kinship into biological hierarchy. A sound reconstruction may correlate language

history, archaeological context and ancestry movement, but it must state the independent evidence and limit at every step. The category firewall does not deny mobility; it prevents mobility from becoming a racial or civilisational essence.

Demand decoding: Define the three categories, show one false equation and end with the methodological gain.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The answer directly distinguishes textual, linguistic and genetic evidence, uses PGW and Rakhigarhi, and qualifies convergence.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Assess the value and limits of the Rig Veda for the Aryan problem. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (124 words):

The Rig Veda is indispensable for early Indo-Aryan language, ritual vocabulary, cattle-centred values, horse-chariot imagery and a broad north-western river world. Its family books help locate an early textual horizon around the Sindhu and its tributaries. Yet the corpus is orally transmitted, layered and ritual-poetic, not a dated migration chronicle or census. A hymn may combine memory, praise, myth and polemic; textual prominence cannot be converted into material frequency. The text also cannot identify the language of Cemetery H, PGW or another archaeological assemblage. Its evidence becomes strongest when clusters of references are compared with external linguistic chronology and independently dated archaeology. The Rig Veda therefore reconstructs a cultural world with exceptional richness, but not an exact route, population count or one-to-one ethnic map.

Demand decoding: Balance value and limitation; include genre, layering, geography and the archaeology boundary.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The model answers "assess", uses named textual features and prevents literalist or dismissive extremes.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Why is migration-and-interaction a better framework than a simple Aryan invasion model? Discuss. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (180 words):

A simple invasion model implies sudden conquest, a broad destruction horizon and substantial replacement. That model does not fit the archaeological record. Harappan cities declined unevenly, the Mohenjo-daro skeletons do not represent one massacre, and Late Harappan regional cultures preserve population and material continuities. This evidence rejects a civilisational destruction story, but not all later mobility.

Comparative linguistics securely places Vedic Sanskrit within Indo-Iranian and Indo-European. Mitanni divine names and horse-training vocabulary provide external Indo-Aryan attestation by the mid-second millennium BCE. BMAC, Sintashta and Swat show interaction corridors and technologies, although no assemblage identifies a language by itself. The 2019 Rakhigarhi genome constrains one Mature Harappan individual, while Narasimhan et al.'s wider dataset supports later Steppe-related ancestry movement alongside extensive IVC-related continuity.

Migration-and-interaction can combine these findings through repeated small movements, pastoral and elite networks, bilingualism, marriage, conflict and borrowing. It explains language spread without requiring an invading race or disappearance of local populations. Exact routes, scale, gender balance and political mechanisms remain debated. The strongest conclusion is therefore mobility plus acculturation and regional synthesis, not invasion or purity.

Demand decoding: Contrast model predictions, test them against archaeology, linguistics and aDNA, then name social mechanisms.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The model uses four independent evidence classes and clearly distinguishes rejection of invasion from rejection of migration.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Can Cemetery H, Gandhara Grave, OCP or PGW identify the speakers of Vedic Sanskrit? Discuss. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (189 words):

Archaeological cultures classify recurring combinations of pottery, burial, house form, tools and diet. They provide chronology and material context, but they do not record speech or self-identified ethnicity unless independent inscriptions or texts exist.

Cemetery H combines Harappan pottery continuity with changed mortuary practices; this indicates transformation, not a named migrant people. Gandhara Grave or Swat spans a long period with varied burials and outside contacts, making a single-wave label untenable. OCP overlaps Late Harappan contexts at some sites, while many copper hoards lack secure stratigraphy. PGW is mainly a later Vedic and early Iron Age comparison; it overlaps Late Harappan material at some settlements but follows it after a break elsewhere.

These horizons can be correlated with textual and linguistic developments only cautiously. Objects may spread through trade, imitation, marriage, specialist mobility or demographic movement, and one language can cross several assemblages. Bhagwanpura is therefore evidence of sequence and interaction, not a bilingual name-tag. Archaeology is indispensable to reconstruct the setting of Vedic cultural formation, but none of these cultures can independently identify Vedic Sanskrit speakers. The correct vocabulary is "associated with", "overlaps with" and "may reflect contact".

Demand decoding: Define archaeological culture, compare all four horizons and finish with a controlled vocabulary.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The model gives each named culture a distinct evidentiary role and explicitly answers the identity question.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Evaluate the contribution and limits of ancient DNA to the Aryan problem. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (202 words):

Ancient DNA has added direct biological evidence to a debate long dominated by text, language and archaeology. It can identify ancestry affinities and admixture in dated sampled individuals, test whether population movement is plausible and compare regions across time.

Shinde et al.'s 2019 *Cell* study recovered one Mature Harappan genome from Rakhigarhi. That individual lacked detectable Steppe-pastoralist ancestry; the result is a significant chronological constraint, not proof about every Harappan or the language of the civilisation. Its Iranian-related component represented a deep lineage rather than a simple recent migration of sampled western farmers.

Narasimhan et al.'s 2019 *Science* study analysed 523 ancient individuals from Central and northern South Asia. It supports later Steppe-related ancestry movement and extensive IVC-related contribution to later South Asian populations. This pattern is consistent with migration and mixture rather than either mass replacement or complete isolation.

Limits remain decisive: preservation and contamination, uneven geographic sampling, cemetery selection, small regional samples, sex bias, reference-population choice and modelled admixture ranges. An ancestry component is not a language, race, caste, religion or self-identity. Genetics is therefore strongest when triangulated with Indo-Iranian linguistics, Mitanni chronology and archaeological contexts. It changes probabilities and chronology; it cannot independently pronounce who was "Aryan".

Demand decoding: Explain method, treat Rakhigarhi and the wider study separately, list sample/model limits, then restore triangulation.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The answer uses dated peer-reviewed studies, exact sample scope and explicit language-culture limits.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Examine the political misuse of the Aryan question and propose a neutral source-criticism framework. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (210 words):

The Aryan question has repeatedly been converted from historical inquiry into a claim about hierarchy or ownership. Colonial philology correctly recognised language relationship but often racialised it, presenting a superior Aryan people as the maker of civilisation. Later nationalist and communal arguments sometimes reversed the conclusion while retaining the same essentialist method: an ancient word, pot, river or genome becomes a certificate of modern purity.

A neutral framework begins with a category firewall. *Arya* is a contextual textual designation; Indo-Aryan is linguistic; archaeological culture records material practice; ancient DNA records sampled ancestry. It then orders chronology: Mature Harappan urbanism largely precedes the conventional Rigvedic horizon, while post-Harappan cultures and Central Asian corridors overlap unevenly.

Each evidence class receives a bounded task. Comparative linguistics establishes descent and contact; Mitanni supplies external attestation; the Rig Veda supplies a layered north-western textual world; archaeology tests material sequence; Rakhigarhi and Narasimhan et al. constrain population history. Competing models are evaluated against all classes. The mass-invasion model fails; complete zero-mobility faces substantial contrary evidence; multi-phase migration and interaction best fit the current record.

Neutrality does not mean equal weight for every claim. It means distinguishing secure facts, probable synthesis and unresolved route, scale, language and identity. Ancient mobility or continuity cannot confer modern political legitimacy.

Demand decoding: Trace misuse, establish the firewall, weigh evidence by function and end with graded confidence.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The model combines historiography, method and a clear verdict without turning uncertainty into false equivalence.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

A1. Comparative Linguistics Beyond Cognate Lists

Comparative reconstruction depends on systems of correspondence and subgroup innovations. A homeland model must fit branching, borrowing and chronology; no single modern phylogenetic tree should be treated as final. Linguistic trees simplify dialect continua and contact.

A2. Contact, Substrate and Retroflexion

Non-Indo-European vocabulary and names in the Rig Veda, and the areal distribution of retroflex consonants, support sustained contact in South Asia. Specific Dravidian, Munda or lost-language attribution requires word-by-word analysis. Contact proves cultural formation more securely than it proves one migration route.

A3. Sex, Region and Social Scale in Population Movement

Migration can be sex-biased or socially selective, but such claims require sexed samples, uniparental markers and autosomal evidence from comparable regions and periods. Elite dominance is one mechanism among several, not a default explanation. Sparse sampling can make a local pattern look universal.

A4. Horse and Chariot as a Technology Package

The strongest argument uses convergent chronology across textual vocabulary, securely identified horse remains and true spoked-wheel vehicles. Technology can diffuse through exchange and emulation. Therefore even a complete package would strengthen, not independently prove, a language attribution.

A5. The Sarasvati Debate as a Model of Source Criticism

Palaeochannel mapping, hydrological discharge, settlement chronology, sediment dating and textual layering must be kept distinct. A major Bronze Age channel does not automatically identify the river praised in a later transmitted text; equally, textual memory cannot be dismissed merely because landscapes changed.

A6. Ethical Communication of Archaeogenetics

Always report paper date, archaeological date, sample number, geographic coverage and inference limit. Avoid racial vocabulary, ownership claims and modern community projection. "Consistent with" is not "genetically proves," and absence in one sample is not absence in every later population.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

1. CATEGORY AND METHOD

- Arya: contextual textual self-designation; not a biological race.
- Indo-Aryan: linguistic subgroup within Indo-Iranian and Indo-European.
- Firewall: language != genes != pottery != ethnicity != civilisation.
- Triangulate only after matching date, place, scale and source independence.

2. SCHOLARLY DEBATE AND CHRONOLOGY

- Philology established language relationship; colonial theory racialised it.
- Wheeler's Harappan-destruction invasion is rejected: no civilisation-wide assault horizon.
- Mature Harappan c. 2600-1900 BCE; Late Harappan c. 1900-1300 BCE, regionally variable.
- Sintashta c. 2100-1800 BCE; BMAC mainly c. 2300-1700 BCE; Mitanni c. 15th-14th centuries BCE.
- Conventional Rigvedic horizon c. 1500/1200-1000 BCE; dates and textual layers remain debated.

3. LINGUISTIC AND TEXTUAL EVIDENCE

- Regular sound laws, grammar and inherited vocabulary establish Indo-European relationship.
- Vedic-Avestan parallels show Indo-Iranian inheritance and later divergence.
- Mitanni provides restricted external Indo-Aryan attestation, not a direct route.
- Rig Veda: layered oral ritual poetry; north-western textual geography; not a migration diary.
- Sarasvati/Ghaggar-Hakra: hydrology, archaeology and textual chronology must be separated.

4. MATERIAL PROFILE AND ARCHAEOLOGY

- Rigvedic vocabulary: pastoral predominance within an agro-pastoral economy.
- Horse presence != horse centrality != light spoked-wheel chariot.
- Surkotada equid debated; Sanauli solid-wheel vehicles do not establish horse-drawn Vedic chariots.
- Cemetery H, Swat, OCP, copper hoards, PGW, BMAC and Sintashta are contexts, not peoples.
- Harappan-to-Vedic bridge: institutional discontinuity with demographic and cultural continuity.

5. COMPETING MODELS

Model	Verdict
Violent mass invasion	Rejected in its Harappan-destruction form
Multi-phase migration	Strong broad fit; route/scale/mechanism debated
Strict zero inward movement	Must overcome linguistics, Mitanni and later ancestry evidence
Interaction synthesis	Best overall: movement + continuity + acculturation + regional variation

6. GENETICS

- Shinde et al., *Cell* 2019: one Rakhigarhi individual lacked detectable Steppe-pastoralist ancestry.
- Do not generalise one person to all Harappans or infer language.
- Narasimhan et al., *Science* 2019: 523 ancient individuals; supports later Steppe-related movement and extensive IVC-related continuity/mixture.
- Check sample, date, place, sex, burial selection, reference model and representativeness.
- No "Aryan gene"; ancestry does not encode language, caste, religion or civilisation.

7. FACT / INTERPRETATION / UNRESOLVED

- Secure: linguistic family; Aryan is not a race; no mass invasion destruction; repeated mixture.
- Probable synthesis: some Indo-Aryan-speaking mobility plus interaction in the second millennium BCE.
- Unresolved: exact homeland/route, scale and sex balance, precise Rigvedic layers, Harappan language, exact material correlates.

8. UPSC ANSWER ROUTE

- Direct routed Aryan-origin/migration PYQs, 2018-2026: zero.
- Adjacent Vedic PYQs belong to Topics 08-09; use only as cultural/source routes.
- Structure: category firewall -> chronology -> linguistics -> text/geography -> archaeology -> genetics -> model comparison -> graded verdict.
- Final line: the evidence supports movement, admixture and acculturation while rejecting racial and one-culture-one-people caricatures.